

Classical music

The term “classical music” is used to describe all of Western art music, even though the music belongs only to the classical period of c.1750–1820. Mainly heard in concert halls, churches, and opera houses, it can be performed anywhere.

SEE ALSO

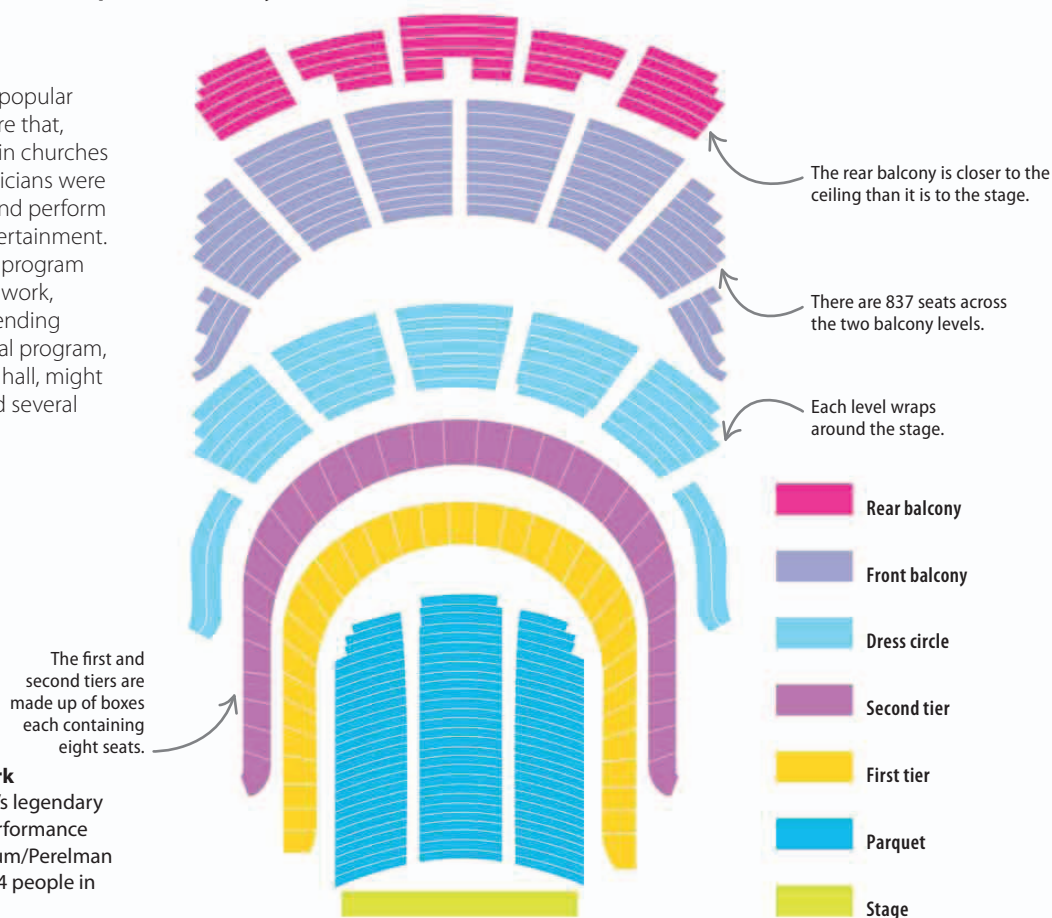
◀ 184–185 The orchestra

The Classical period

212–213 ▶

Concerts

Public concerts became popular in the 19th century. Before that, music was mainly heard in churches and courts at which musicians were employed to compose and perform music for worship or entertainment. Now, a typical orchestral program might open with a short work, followed by a concerto, ending with a symphony. A recital program, often played in a smaller hall, might include a solo sonata and several shorter pieces.



▷ Carnegie Hall, New York

Opened in 1891, New York's legendary Carnegie Hall has three performance spaces. The Stern Auditorium/Perelman Stage accommodates 2,804 people in six different seating zones.

Period performance

“Period” or “historically informed” performance is a way of performing Western music and theater. In this approach, performers play instruments that are copies of those that would have been in use at the time the work was composed. These “original” instruments allow us to hear music as the composer intended: quieter sounds, clearer textures, and at a pitch considerably lower than is used in modern performances.

▷ Oboe da caccia

Johann Sebastian Bach occasionally wrote for the curved “hunting” oboe. The cor anglais is its nearest modern equivalent, sounding deeper, richer notes than the oboe.



In October 2014, a huge **orchestra of 1,000 performers** assembled in Sacramento to play part of **Beethoven's ninth symphony**.